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The Railway and Union Budgets have promised the moon to the people of West Bengal

Perhaps no two Union ministers' overall policy directions have been so tuned towards one region as this year's Railways and Union Budgets. While Mamata Banerjee was unabashed in her largesse for West Bengal, Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee has been more temperate in his actions. Both ministers, though, have clearly set their eyes on the state elections of 2011. Banerjee's Budget was almost a Bengal Budget. She said, "I come from Bengal and if I am

seen to be pro-Bengal, so be it." She also announced a land bank to counter her anti-industry image and even included Maoist-infested areas for new trains and power stations.

Mukherjee too made it a Bengal bonanza giving the Government Rs 1,000 crore it had demanded for Cyclone Aila victims and also promised a mega industry cluster. However, what has taken the wind out of the CPI(M)'s sails is the whopping 144 per cent increase in investment over last year in rural schemes, the



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CPI(M)'s traditional vote-bank. Also, the Indian Museum and the Asiatic Society—in limelight for mismanagement—have got huge fund allocations. Mukherjee also ensured that Murshidabad, a part of his parlia-

mentary constituency, got Rs 25 crore to set up a campus of the Aligarh Muslim University. A cave of treasures is about to open in West Bengal but the prize will be known only in 2011.

by Abhijit Dasgupta

Nandigram and Lalgarh to link them to her political roadmap. Between them, the three places capture the decline of the Left and rise of a new Banerjee. "There is no other point in announcing the surveys. The surveys to link Singur to Nandigram or the railway to Salboni-Jhargram through Lalgarh and Belpahari may take years to fructify, if at all," claimed a railway official. Connecting Lalgarh to the railway network is, in Banerjee's political calculations, forging a new connection with the state's tribal network. The lack of presence in the tribal belt has been one of the weaknesses of the Trinamool Congress. Mamata had made her intentions clear soon after taking over the reins of the Railway Ministry when she announced a Rs 20 monthly railway pass for people with income less than Rs 500 per month—all for the benefit of daily commuters

in Kolkata locals and Metro.

Taking over from Lalu, she could do little to get her people in place at a senior level in the Railway Board. Most of them had just been brought in by her predecessor before he demitted office. However, she bent some rules to bring in her trusted officers at crucial levels in West Bengal. She got the orders reverted for postings of divisional railway managers in Sealdah, Asansol and Adra, to get officers of her choice for the crucial posts. In Sealdah, for example, she opted for P. Guha, who was the Executive Director (Coaching) in the Railway Board.

Banerjee is aiming for the top job in the state not merely by her own efforts. She is also believed to have told her six MPs, inducted as ministers of state that they should not "unnecessarily spend time" in Delhi and concentrate on West Bengal instead. Her aides,

however, deny that she is treating the Railways as a means to the Writers' Building. They say that her long stays in West Bengal were prompted first by the Aila cyclone and then the Lalgarh siege. "Also, whenever she is in Delhi, she makes it a point to clear important files and look into pending issues," said an aide. In fact, Banerjee herself had defended her style of functioning. The day she took over, she said that what eventually mattered was performance and not the place of operation. "If I stay in Delhi 365 days of the year and my performance is zero, of what use will it be?" she had questioned. However, most in the Railways and some in the government believe that Banerjee's presence in Kolkata has a higher purpose, mainly to derail the shell-shocked Left Front Government and switch tracks from Central minister to chief minister. ■